The Target School List

The tier decides how many bankers answer an email you didn't have to send. It does not decide who gets the offer. Read the list for what a school hands you for free: a recruiting calendar, a résumé book, an alumni base that replies. Assume everything else is on you. Culture fit is the tiebreaker; all of these are competitive.

> **HOW TO READ THE TIERS**
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> A tier is placement, not prestige. What separates one line from the next is on-campus presence, alumni density on the desks you want, and how many kids at that school are chasing the same seat. Half-tiers exist because a distinction had to be made somewhere; do not over-read them. Population size and finance-hardo culture move a school more than rank does.

Tier 1 · Best of the Best

School	What it hands you
HYPSM Harvard · Yale · Princeton · Stanford · MIT	Huge networks, heavy on-campus recruiting. First rounds from basically every bank with a bit of networking. Prepare well and it is your offer to lose.
UPenn Wharton	Same access, aimed straight at the desks. If you get into one of these it is almost a decision that makes itself, unless it is a matter of money, and then you look elsewhere.

Not a bad trade to graduate with some debt and an amazing job. That is a personal call, not a recruiting one.

Tier 1.5 · High Targets

School	What it hands you
UChicago · Duke	Equivalent to some Ivies. Very good networks and constantly improving. Wildly different from each other culturally; both place very well.
UPenn (non-Wharton) Dartmouth · Columbia · Cornell Dyson	Also Ivies. Non-Wharton Penn is easily still a target school. You cannot go wrong with any of these. The only real question is culture fit.

All insanely competitive. If you are competitive enough, apply to several or all of them.

Tier 2 and Tier 2.5

These are the schools that send kids to banks in volume. The half-tier line between them is thin on purpose: it is population size, on-campus presence, and how many people on that campus want the same seat. Nothing below this line is a fallback.

Tier 2 · Target

School	What it hands you
UMich Ross NYU Stern · UVA McIntire	All send huge numbers to banks, with the competition to match. Michigan is a great college experience, maybe the best. NYU is the most unique. UVA is Greek-life heavy with a southern-school appeal. Argue for any of the three and you are not wrong.
Cornell (non-Dyson) Brown	Non-Dyson Cornell is still a target. So is Brown, where fewer kids want to be bankers. Cornell is bigger; Brown is smaller and more its own thing.

The first three are easier to get into, but not by much. Good ED II options, or even ED I, especially Cornell.

Tier 2.5 · Target, a Teeny Bit Below

School	What it hands you
Georgetown McDonough UCB Haas	Similar to Ross and Stern. Big populations, stiff competition, and a lot of people sent to banks. Both are amazing environments, with Berkeley the huge-state-school experience.
Notre Dame Mendoza	Great recruiting, more regional but also country-wide. Great school culture and a real balance between work and play.
Northwestern	Similar to UChicago, sends smaller numbers. Plenty of motivated and unusual people.
Amherst · Williams	Great LACs if that is your cup of tea. Not everyone fits into a small liberal arts college, but if you thrive in a small environment, do not be afraid to look.

These are more unique schools; not everyone has them on a list. Competitiveness is the same as the tier above. Aside from Georgetown and Berkeley, investment banking is not a hugely preferred path at any of them.

The Semi-Targets

Below the half-tier line the schools stop being interchangeable. Placement gets more regional, the populations get bigger, and banking stops being the default path, which cuts both ways. Fewer competitors on campus, fewer bankers already on the phone with you.

Tier 3 · Semi-Target

School	What it hands you
Vanderbilt · WashU Olin USC Marshall	Great regional presence, with USC into the West Coast banks, but they fare well across the board. Good private schools with good cultures. Still competitive.
UNC Kenan-Flagler UT Austin McCombs · UCLA	Good public schools with good recruiting. A step below UVA, Berkeley, and Michigan for placement. Amazing cultures.
Emory Goizueta	Good school. Smaller, and not a great fit for every kid; keep that in mind.
JHU	Fewer want to be bankers, but it is very possible.
Rice	Often overlooked. Great placement into the Houston banks.
Indiana Kelley	Feeds well into the Chicago offices. Amazing school culture, and the population is big enough that they send a decent number to banking.
Boston College	Small-to-mid population. Nice culture, more its own thing.

These are all pretty equal. What changes is population size and finance-hardo culture. Some could be argued into the tier above, but more of them place regionally, and the big populations pull the bankers-per-capita number down.

> **IF YOUR SCHOOL IS NOT ON THIS LIST**
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> The list ends here; the job does not. Everything past this page is about the schools nobody sends a banker to, and the one thing that closes the gap.

The Non-Target Playbook

If your school is not on the list, nothing above changes what you are capable of. It changes who starts the conversation. At a target, the bank shows up on campus and networking accelerates a process that was already running. At a non-target, nothing is running until you start it. Networking is not a supplement to the process. It is the process.

> **THE TRADE**
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> A target sophomore sends twenty emails off the on-campus list and gets eight replies. You will send a hundred and fifty and get twenty. That is the whole difference, and it is a fair one: it costs you time, not talent. Start early enough that the time is there to spend. Freshman spring is not too early; junior fall is late.

Five Rules

Rule	Why
Alumni before strangers	One alum on the desk is worth thirty cold names. Search LinkedIn by school *and* bank, not bank alone. The 2019 grad from your school owes you nothing and answers anyway. That is the entire edge you have.
Volume, then volume	Reply rate is the one number you cannot negotiate, so negotiate the numerator. Log every send: name, desk, date out, date bumped, outcome. Review it once a week.
Diversity and early-ID programs	Every bank runs them, they are the fastest route in from a non-target, and the deadlines land sophomore year. Miss them and you wait a full cycle.
Boutique first, bulge later	Nobody starts at the top. A summer at a regional or boutique M&A shop turns your next round of emails into ones a banker can actually answer.
Technicals cold, no excuses	A target kid gets forgiven for fumbling a WACC question. You will not. Preparation is the one bar you control completely, so clear it before the first call, not after.

Transferring is a real path, and plenty do it into Ross or Stern, but it is not the only one, and a year spent networking beats a year spent on an application. Decide once, then stop relitigating it.

The list decides who replies. You decide who you email.

Take the 60-second quiz and get a personalized outreach list built around your target desks.

TAKE THE QUIZ → wallstalpha.com/apply

Educational only; not affiliated with or endorsed by any school or firm named. Tiers are one person's opinion and are not a ranking of academic quality. Always verify current openings and eligibility on the official career page before applying.